

Q Which distribution do you use, and which desktop environment?

I use openSUSE as my main distro, with Gentoo still on a few server or 'tiny' machines I use for infrastructure. I use SLED for testing new hardware out as part of my job.

As for the desktop environment, my laptop is now running Moblin. Before that it was running Fluxbox. My main desktop is running GNOME, and I have a test box running KDE to ensure that the FACTORY branch of openSUSE is still working properly.

Q What books and programming language(s) would you recommend to aspiring kernel developers?

For kernel developers, C is essential—that's all the kernel is written in. (OK, a tiny amount of assembly is also used, but that's usually never touched by anyone any more.)

Books for kernel development include:

- *Linux Kernel in a Nutshell*, for how to build and install a custom kernel. This is the place to start if you don't know how to do this. [It's freely available online at www.kroah.com/lkn]
- *Linux Device Drivers*, Third Edition, is a bit outdated, but still a good overview of Linux drivers and how to develop them. [It's freely available online at lwn.net/Kernel/LDD3]
- *Understanding the Linux Kernel* is a good overall kernel development book, as is *Linux Kernel Development*, Second Edition, although both of them are getting a bit out of date these days.

Q Is there any difference between the present generation of developers as compared to the first?

I don't think there is any difference. We are all unique and different people, just like everyone else :-)

Q A lot of people point out that even Linux/free software developers use an Apple Mac. What do you say about that?

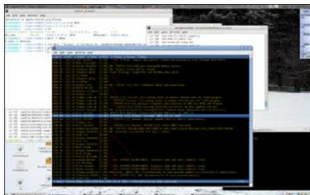
I don't tell you what code to run, you don't tell me what to run, and we will all be happy.

Q What are your key areas of responsibility at Novell? Do you work full time on the Kernel?

I work on the Linux Driver Project with Novell's blessings. I've also been involved lately in some work to get Moblin working well within openSUSE, which has been a lot of fun playing with a wide range of different netbooks. All of this is related to the kernel, so I do work full time on it.

Q What was the idea behind LDP (Linux Driver Project)? How many of its goals have been achieved?

You can see my longer response for this at www.kroah.com/log/linux/linux_driver_project_status-2009-06.html [reproduced as sidebar titled "linux kernel



Greg's GNOME desktop

monkey log" on the next page]; hopefully that answers this question sufficiently.

Q We have been experiencing better driver support on Linux as compared to competing operating systems. What is the reason behind this? How different is the Linux driver development model compared to its competitors?

The development model is very different. All drivers for Linux end up in the main kernel tree, which allows the drivers to always stay up to date with the kernel, and for a lot of good optimisation and fixes to be made. It is very powerful to be able to look at a large number of drivers that all do the same thing, and merge them together into a smaller code base that is easier to maintain. This happens all the time in Linux, and has turned out to work very well.

Q How hard is it to convince companies to work with the project? Theo de Raadt [Open BSD project head] has been quite successful with Taiwanese companies in terms of hardware support. What is your approach?

It has been very easy to convince companies so far. We have worked with Taiwanese companies, as well as European- and US-based companies—there is no difference between countries.

Q Companies like ATI and NVIDIA have still maintained a distance from Linux. What is the status currently?

ATI hasn't. They have released the specifications for their hardware, which has allowed an open driver to be written. NVIDIA has its own reasons for doing what it does. I suggest asking them about this if you are interested.

Q Although binary-only drivers make life easy for the end user, in your opinion, how good are they?

They do not make life easy for end users; they make life harder. My opinion, as well as those of a very large number of Linux kernel contributors, was published last year and can be seen at www.linuxfoundation.org/en/Kernel_Driver_Statement.